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BLOOD ON THE STREETS

Members of the Outlaws take stock of the destruction from years of battles with rival gangs — and seek atonement



Last in a series

By Bob Hohler
GLOBE STAFF

‘You’re my brother,” Odair Fernandes said into the phone. He was calling from a cell block at MCI-Norfolk. He and Milton DoSouto, once gang brothers, talked most every day. He’d been behind bars for more than a decade now, convicted of a brutal murder to avenge the shooting that left Milton partially paralyzed.

Police said that Odair had run into the street that day when Milton fell, firing a gun at the shooter’s car as it sped away and that he ran back to kneel over Milton’s bullet-ridden body, shouting, “Somebody’s going to die for this.”

Eleven nights later, according to prosecutors, Odair was in a group of seven that hunted down two friends of the enemy Wendover gang and opened fire. One was killed instantly. Another, a nephew of the peace activist Isaura Mendes, was paralyzed from the neck down and died four years later.

DOSOUTO, Page A6



PHOTOS BY CRAIG F. WALKER/GLOBE STAFF

Odair Fernandes (top) has been imprisoned at MCI-Norfolk for a shooting that killed one man and paralyzed another. His wife, Deanna Neal Fernandes, joined son, Camden Neal, at an antiviolence forum.

‘Manchester took it on the chin in the election cycle.’

SCOTT SPRADLING, *public relations consultant*

N.H. city tackling stereotypes in rebranding effort

By Amanda Gokee
GLOBE STAFF

MANCHESTER, N.H. — The warnings began soon after Evan Lang moved here with his family.

“Don’t open anything in Manchester,” was the message he received after asking for advice on

starting a bakery. “People keep saying, ‘There’s a reason it’s called Manchvegas,’” said Lang.

It was the first time Lang, who lived previously in New Jersey, Israel, and Philadelphia, encountered Manchester’s reputation as dangerous, run down, and wrestling with

drug issues and homelessness. But the warnings didn’t deter Lang, who opened Dishon Bakery on the city’s main street anyway.

Lang is part of a growing movement of city leaders, business owners, and residents working to give Manchester a much-needed make-

over. New Hampshire’s largest city — an urban island of about 115,500 residents in a rural, rapidly purpling state, has long had a negative reputation, with the derogative “Manchvegas” moniker alluding to stereotypes about urban vice and

MANCHESTER, Page A10

European leaders fret over US-Russia

Caught on sidelines, they work to establish strategy for postwar Ukraine

By Catherine Porter and Steven Erlanger
NEW YORK TIMES

PARIS — The leaders of many of Europe’s biggest countries came to Paris on Monday in an urgent effort to forge a strategy for their own security, as President Trump’s envoys prepared for talks with Russia over ending the war in Ukraine without them.

The meeting in Paris was pulled together hastily after the visit to Europe last week by Vice President JD Vance and Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, which left European leaders alarmed by both the tone and message of the new Trump administration and what it might hold for the Continent.

European leaders were shocked by the hostility of Vance’s scathing speech in Munich criticizing Europe’s exclusion of far-right groups from power and the sudden US plans to begin peace talks with Russia in Saudi Arabia, starting Tuesday, without the presence of Ukrainian or European leaders.

Trump’s phone call last week to Russian President Vladimir Putin broke ranks with most European allies who have tried to isolate the man who ordered the invasion of sovereign Ukraine three years ago next week.

The meetings with the new US officials sparked fear that the United States wants to pull thousands

UKRAINE, Page A4

Leveled classes remain despite push to curtail

Most districts retain some ability grouping, data show

By Christopher Huffaker
GLOBE STAFF

In recent years, districts across Massachusetts have been increasingly driven by controversies around advanced courses, with school systems scaling back accelerated options and provoking backlash from parents and sometimes teachers.

Among them: Boston eliminated its elementary school “advanced work classes.” Brookline axed honors social studies in ninth grade. Newton Public Schools introduced mixed-level classrooms across all core subjects in high school, with students at different achievement levels learning alongside one another but earning different credits.

School leaders argue these changes will reduce segregation and achievement gaps and offer rigorous coursework to more students; opponents fear it will instead make teaching more difficult and water down rigor for advanced students while the wealthy flee to private schools or pricey after-school classes. Research is mixed, with different studies finding both positive and negative effects of tracking.

LEVELED COURSES, Page B4

Proclaimed leader of cultlike group arrested in Md.

By John Hilliard
GLOBE STAFF

Three members of the “Zizians” — a cultlike group linked to violence — were arrested on a rural road during an unruly encounter with Maryland State Police, who accused them of trespassing on private property and hindering officers while two of the suspects were hit with firearms charges, authorities said Monday.

The group, with roots in the San Francisco Bay Area, has been the focus of an intense multistate probe as investigators allege members are tied to at least six deaths in three states — including a US border patrol agent in Vermont last month, a California man a few days earlier, and a Pennsylvania couple in 2022.

The three suspects arrested on Sunday include the reputed leader, Jack Amadeus LaSota, who goes

ARREST, Page A10



STAN GROSSFELD/GLOBE STAFF

FEAR IN THE SHADOWS — Draped in a Mexican flag, a US citizen who asked that her name not be used said she fears her mother, who is in the process of getting citizenship, could be targeted for deportation. Such concerns are rampant in the immigrant community. **B1.**



Go into freeze fall

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Wednesday: Clouds return.
High 27-32, low 10-15.

Sunrise: 6:36. Sunset: 5:20.

Weather and comics, **D4-5.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

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Four top New York City officials said they would resign after the Justice Department moved to dismiss its corruption case against Mayor Eric Adams. **A2.**

Add “more rats in Boston” to the list of problems created by climate change. **B1.**

Canada’s win over Finland in Boston sets up a bruising rematch with the US team in the finals of the 4 Nations Face-Off hockey tourney. **C1.**

Massachusetts economic groups are pressing the Legislature to prioritize affordability and competitiveness in its session. **D1.**